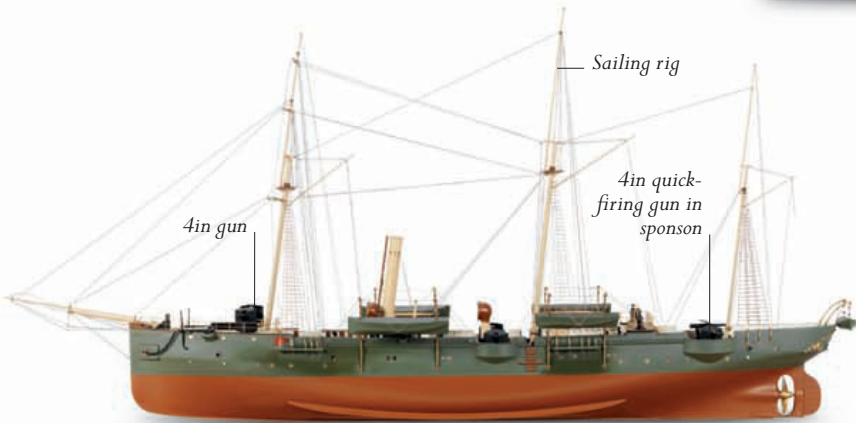


EARLY CRUISERS

Prior to the 1880s, the term “cruiser” was not recognized as a single group of ships, being composed of frigates, corvettes, and sloops. By the 1890s, however, the new class had taken on a well-defined identity of its own. Capable of long-range action independently of battle fleets, cruisers were able to engage in commerce raiding or to protect national interests in far-flung places. By the turn of the century, cruisers had become the single largest class of warship in service; some navies never commissioned a more powerful, or modern, vessel.



▲ HMS RATTLER
Commissioned 1887 Origin UK
Displacement 810 tons
Length 50.3m (165ft)
Top speed 13 knots

A “composite gunboat”, with wooden hull-planking on iron frames, the *Rattler* was one of a group of about 30 essentially similar general-purpose, small warships built between 1875 and 1890 for colonial service in Africa and Asia.

▼ HMS GIBRALTAR
Commissioned 1894 Origin UK
Displacement 7,700 tons
Length 118.1m (387ft)
Top speed 18 knots

One of a class of nine first-class protected cruisers – with armoured decks and no side-armour, but with coal loaded in the hull to give protection – the *Gibraltar* was built for service in the tropics, and its steel hull was clad in wood and copper.



▲ SEIKI
Commissioned 1876 Origin Japan
Displacement 900 tons
Length 61m (200ft)
Top speed 9.5 knots

Barque-rigged (with square sails on the fore- and main masts and fore and aft on the mizzen) and wooden-hulled, the screw-sloop *Seiki* was the first ship built at the Yokosuka Navy Yard, to a French design.



▲ TAKAO
Commissioned 1889 Origin Japan
Displacement 1,750 tons
Length 70.4m (231ft)
Top speed 15 knots

The first steel-hulled warship built in Japan, the *Takao* was devoid of all protection save for its armament. Built to a French design (by Émile Bertin), and under French supervision, it showed considerable Gallic influence.

